



CONSISTENTLY THROWING ABOVE 80M DESPITE BEING FAR FROM HIS PERSONAL BEST INDICATES THAT SHIVPAL IS CAPABLE OF MUCH BIGGER THROWS



far from his personal best indicates that he is capable of much bigger throws. This is evident from his 81.96m at Bhubaneswar and 81.11m gold-winning effort at the National Games in Goa.

"I was really unfit before I returned to competition in Bhubaneswar. In fact, just before the National Games, I hadn't even been training for a month because I was posted at Naliya Air Force Base (near the border with Pakistan in Gujarat's Sir Creek area). There isn't any training facility there apart from a general purpose gym. I just did basic training and came to Goa. Very honestly, if you give me enough warm-up time, I'll always be confident of at least making an 80m

throw," he says.

Shivpal isn't even particularly concerned about the 85.50m qualification standard. "I've achieved that mark before so it's not something that I think will be hard to get. Even now it's just a matter of finding the right angle of release. I know that if I stay injury-free until the start of next season, I'll get it very quickly," he says.

If Shivpal isn't sweating about qualifying for the Olympics, Manu isn't either. Although he's fairly likely to qualify through the ranking system and is almost certain to rank higher than Shivpal because of his performance at the 2023 Worlds and Asian Championships, Manu believes he can qualify directly. "I am not merely thinking of just qualifying for the Olympics. I am thinking about how I can make a big throw — something close to 90m at the Olympics," he says.

"I actually thought I had a good season last year. Although, I had a better season's best in 2022 (84.35m), I was lot more consistent in 2023 (he crossed 80m in all but one competition). I actually thought I would qualify for the Olympics in 2023 itself. I had three competitions where I was feeling good and was throwing well — Indian Grand Prix (84.33m), World Championships (84.11) and Open Athletics Championships (82.06m) — but I made some basic errors in each of them. I got my best throw in these competitions from a release that was around 2 meters short of the foul line. It's a small technical error that I've been working on," says Manu.

"Compared to last year I'm a lot

stronger. I still have a slightly bent knee that I'm trying to correct but other than that I feel I'm getting a lot of power behind my throws. I've crossed 85m twice in training and am regularly in the 83m-84m range. So I know it's not going to be very difficult to make that throw in competition also."

If both Manu and Shivpal say they aren't looking at just touching the 85.50m magic mark, it's because neither thinks that just getting it would be enough to secure the Olympic berth. AFI president Sumariwalla has said as much. "It would be unfair to say what the selection criteria will be if multiple athletes secure the Olympic qualification standard because that's not happened just yet. But I can see it is going to be a bit of a challenging situation. With the exception of Neeraj I don't think we can say anyone is going to be guaranteed a spot. I think a lot will come down to current form as well," he says.

Manu agrees with that assessment. "I know I can't depend on just getting 85.50m and thinking that it will take me to the Olympics. There's no guarantee of that. I don't think qualification will come on the basis of ranking. And I also don't think there's any guarantee that just because someone does 85.50m, they will be going to the Olympics. I know Shivpal *bhai* is also very strong and capable of getting to 85.50m. Rohit is also coming back from injury, but he's also a very good thrower. All of us will have to try and throw as much above 85.50m as possible," he says.

That being said, both Manu and Shivpal are counting down to the first competition of the season. "The first competition of the season is the Indian Grand Prix on March 22. I think it will be important to hit the qualifying standard as early as possible because it will be a good confidence boost.

"After that we can prepare to increase that mark," says Shivpal. "The goal for any athlete isn't just to qualify for the Olympics. It's to prepare ourselves in such a way that we can make a big throw in Paris," he says.